BUSINESS PLAN • OCTOBER 2026 • PLANNING DOCUMENT - NOT AN OFFER OF SECURITIES

AI Data Center Business Plan

How to launch, fund, staff and grow a company that sells power, cooling and GPU capacity to the AI economy - built in phases, anchored by signed customers, and grounded in published market data.



Cover image: illustration, not a photograph of a real facility.

945 TWh

Global demand by 2030. IEA base case, up from 415 TWh in 2024 - more than double in six years.

$9-15M

Per MW to build the shell. Land, building, power and cooling, before servers and GPUs.

3 phases

Build only against demand. Powered shell first, halls fitted out as tenants sign.

24 / 7

Operations from day one. Critical facilities cover is a cost of entry, not an upgrade.

> **The one-sentence strategy:** Secure power and an anchor customer before you pour concrete, sell capacity in phases, and let efficiency - measured by Power Usage Effectiveness (PUE) - protect your margin on every megawatt you sell.

All market figures in this plan are dated and sourced on page 10. Cost ranges are planning benchmarks from published industry sources, not quotes. Get site-specific engineering and legal advice before committing capital.

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The business at a glance

What you sell

Reliable megawatts, cooled rack space and GPU compute by the hour, month or multi-year contract - with uptime, security and PUE written into the contract.

Who pays

AI labs and cloud firms that need capacity faster than they can build it, plus enterprises that need private, compliant AI infrastructure.

How you make money

Long-term take-or-pay capacity contracts, colocation rent per kilowatt, and premium GPU cloud rates - against power bought as cheaply and cleanly as possible.

What can kill it

Building before power is secured, fitting out halls without signed tenants, and letting power costs eat the margin. This plan is sequenced to avoid all three.

How to use this plan: Founders read pages 3-7 in order. Lenders and partners will jump to page 7 (finance) and page 9 (risks). Hiring managers start on page 8. Keep the plan as a living document - review it quarterly against the measures on page 9.

Power is the product - and demand is doubling

An AI data center is not a property business with computers in it. It is an energy business that happens to sell compute. This plan treats it that way from the first page.

The International Energy Agency (IEA), in *Energy and AI* (April 2025), puts global data center electricity use at 415 terawatt-hours (TWh) in 2024 - about 1.5% of world electricity - and projects 945 TWh by 2030 in its base case. Demand from AI-optimised facilities is projected to more than quadruple over the same period, and accelerated servers - the GPU systems that train and run AI models - are the fastest-growing driver.

In the United States, the IEA expects data centers to account for almost half of the growth in electricity demand between now and 2030. That is why grid connection, not land or buildings, is now the scarce asset. Developers with secured power and a credible build plan can sell capacity years before it is energised.

The opportunity in one paragraph

Hyperscalers and AI labs are spending at historic scale, but they cannot build everywhere, fast enough, alone. A focused regional operator that secures power early, builds an efficient powered shell, and fits out halls against signed contracts can win durable, contracted revenue without trying to outspend the giants - by being faster, local and easier to deal with.

Three commitments this plan makes

- **No speculative fit-out.** The shell is built once; expensive GPU halls are fitted out only against signed demand or a funded GPU cloud launch.
- **Efficiency is margin.** Every 0.1 improvement in PUE is power you do not buy for cooling and can sell as IT load instead.
- **Contracts before concrete.** An anchor tenant, a power purchase agreement (PPA) or a grid agreement comes before major construction spend at each phase.

> **Honest limit:** This is a planning document, not a forecast for any specific site. No live facility data is included - there is no facility yet. Every number that matters for a real investment must be re-priced for your site, utility and customers.

Four buyers, four different reasons to pay

Do not sell "data center space." Sell the specific outcome each buyer cannot get fast enough on their own.

Buyer	What they need	What they pay a premium for	Contract shape
Hyperscalers & AI labs	Large blocks of power, fast, for training clusters	Speed to power, scale, liquid cooling, expansion rights	Multi-year, take-or-pay, whole halls or buildings
GPU cloud customers	GPU hours without buying hardware	Latest GPUs, high-speed networking, flexible terms	Reserved capacity + on-demand hours
Enterprises	Private AI inference, data control, compliance	Security, certifications, dedicated cages, support	Colocation per kW, 3-5 year terms
Public sector & research	Sovereign, auditable compute	Data residency, clearances, transparent pricing	Framework agreements, grant-funded projects

What the market evidence says

- Global demand more than doubles by 2030 in the IEA base case (415 TWh in 2024 to 945 TWh in 2030), with the US and China together accounting for most of the growth.
- AI workloads grow fastest: demand from AI-optimised data centers is projected to more than quadruple by 2030.
- Supply is constrained by grid queues, transformer and switchgear lead times, and skilled labour - which is why secured, permitted sites command attention.
- Efficiency gains per AI task are real, but total use still rises because adoption grows faster - plan for growth, price for efficiency.

> **Positioning:** "Power-secured AI capacity, delivered in phases, in [your region] - with published PUE, transparent pricing and a local team that answers the phone." Compete on speed, trust and efficiency, not on being cheapest per megawatt.

Sell three products from one facility

1. Powered shell

You provide land, building, power and cooling to the rack. The tenant brings IT. Lowest risk, longest contracts, ideal for an anchor tenant.

2. Colocation

You provide racks, power per kilowatt, cooling, security and remote hands. Enterprises and smaller AI firms rent by the rack or cage.

3. GPU cloud

You own the GPUs and rent compute by the hour or on reservation. Highest margin and highest risk - launch only with funded hardware and committed users.

Plus: managed services

Monitoring, maintenance windows, compliance reporting and connectivity. Small revenue, high stickiness - tenants who buy services renew.

Three facility profiles - match the building to the workload

Profile	Typical scale	Best for	Watch out for
Edge	Small, close to users	Low-latency inference, local enterprise	Higher cost per MW, limited expansion
Regional	Mid-scale campus, one metro	Colocation + GPU cloud mix, anchor tenant	Grid capacity ceiling - secure headroom early
Campus	100 MW-class, phased buildings	Hyperscale training, wholesale tenants	Capital intensity - never build a phase uncontracted

Recommended start: a Regional profile with a powered-shell anchor hall, one colocation hall, and room - in land and power - to grow toward Campus scale. It balances contract security against capital at risk.

Choose the site for power first, land second

Site scorecard - score every candidate out of 5 on each line

Factor	What good looks like
Grid power & timeline	Confirmed capacity, a named substation, and a connection date in writing from the utility
Power price & mix	Competitive tariff, renewable PPA options, and a path to cleaner power over time
Fibre & latency	Two or more carriers, diverse routes, low latency to your target customers
Land & planning	Room to expand, supportive local authority, no fatal flood, noise or height constraints
Water & cooling	A cooling design the local climate and water rules can sustain year-round
People	Electricians, HVAC technicians and network staff within commuting distance
Risk	Low flood, storm and seismic exposure; insurable at a sane price

Build in phases - the sequence that protects cash

- **Phase 0 - Secure (months 0-6):** site option, grid application, anchor-tenant discussions, permits. Small spend, maximum option value.
- **Phase 1 - Shell (months 6-24):** substation, shell building, cooling plant sized for Phase 1 halls, first hall fitted out against the anchor contract.
- **Phase 2 - Grow (months 24-36):** second hall and colocation fit-out as occupancy proves out; GPU cloud only if funded and pre-sold.
- **Phase 3 - Expand:** second building or campus growth, funded from contracted revenue and a new capital round.

> **Design rules:** Design for liquid cooling and high rack density from day one even if the first hall is air-cooled; separate electrical rooms so maintenance never means downtime; and meter everything - you cannot sell or save power you do not measure.

Finance: GPUs cost more than the building

Published benchmarks put a 100 MW hyperscale shell at roughly $900 million to $1.5 billion - $9 million to $15 million per MW for land, building, power and cooling - *before* IT equipment. Servers, networking and GPUs for the same site can add $2.5 billion to $4 billion or more. Treat every figure below as a planning range to re-price, not a quote.

Cost block	Planning range	Notes
Land & site works	Varies widely by market	Often tens of millions for a 50+ acre campus site
Electrical systems	~50% of shell cost	Substation, switchgear, UPS, generators - the heart of the build
Mechanical & cooling	~15-20% of shell cost	Rises with liquid cooling and high-density GPU halls
Shell total (ex-IT)	$9-15M per MW	$900M-$1.5B for 100 MW, per published benchmarks
IT: servers, GPUs, network	Often 2-3x the shell	GPUs at $25,000-$40,000 each in volume dominate this line
Annual operating costs	Power is #1	Then staff, maintenance, insurance, connectivity, water

Funding stack - in the order most founders use it

- **Founder / sponsor equity** for Phase 0: site, studies, grid application, legal.
- **Anchor-tenant pre-commitment** to unlock construction debt - lenders fund contracted megawatts far more readily than speculative ones.
- **Senior debt and infrastructure funds** for the shell; **equipment finance or leasing** for GPUs, whose life is far shorter than the building's.
- **Grants and incentives** where available - energy, broadband and regional development programs change often, so verify on the official portals below.

Company finance links - verify eligibility on the official site

- U.S. Small Business Administration - loans & funding: https://www.sba.gov/funding-programs
- U.S. Department of Energy - Loan Programs Office: https://www.energy.gov/lpo
- Grants.gov - search federal grants: https://www.grants.gov/
- U.S. Treasury - CDFI Fund: https://www.cdfifund.gov/
- Visa - business cards & financing finder: https://usa.visa.com/run-your-business/small-business-tools.html

Links checked as official portals at publication. Programs, rates and deadlines change - confirm on the site before applying, and never pay a third party to "guarantee" a grant or loan.

Staff the facility before you energise it

A data center runs 24 hours a day, 365 days a year. Hiring is not a launch-week task - critical staff must be in place, trained and drilled before the first tenant load arrives.

Team	Key roles	Hire when
Critical facilities	Facilities manager, electrical & mechanical technicians, HVAC technicians, controls / BMS technician	During construction - they witness testing and commissioning
IT operations	Data center technicians, network engineers, NOC technicians, systems administrators	Before first hall fit-out completes
Security & compliance	Security lead and officers, compliance / audit support	Before any tenant equipment arrives
Commercial & support	Sales / capacity planning, finance, HR, customer support	From Phase 0 - selling and funding are day-one jobs
Construction (Phase 1-2)	Project manager, electrical & mechanical engineers, commissioning agent	Contract or hire for the build, retain commissioning knowledge

Pay benchmarks - U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) medians, May 2025, via industry summary

Use these only as a starting point for budgeting: construction managers $114,990; electrical engineers $120,630; mechanical engineers $104,110; network and computer systems administrators $99,130; electricians $63,190; HVAC mechanics and installers $61,010. Local rates in hot data center markets run well above national medians - budget for competition.

Business employment links - recruit and check the rules

- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics - Occupational Outlook: https://www.bls.gov/ooh/
- U.S. Department of Labor - employer resources: https://www.dol.gov/agencies/eta/employers
- CareerOneStop - hiring & workforce (DOL): https://www.careeronestop.org/BusinessCenter
- AWS Careers - data center roles (see how hyperscalers scope the jobs): https://www.amazon.jobs/en/teams/aws-data-center
- LinkedIn Talent Solutions: https://business.linkedin.com/talent-solutions • Indeed for Employers: https://www.indeed.com/hire

> **Retention matters more than recruiting:** trained critical facilities staff are poached constantly. Pay fairly, fund certifications, rotate on-call humanely, and cross-train - a team that stays is an uptime feature.

Plan for the risks that actually bite

Risk	Early warning sign	Mitigation in this plan
Grid delay	Connection date slips, queue position unclear	Phase 0 grid proof before major spend; phased capacity; on-site generation options assessed
Power price rises	Tariff or PPA price above model	PPA + tariff mix, PUE discipline, pass-through clauses in tenant contracts
GPU supply & obsolescence	Lead times stretch, new chip generation announced	Lease / finance GPUs, stagger refresh, sell reserved capacity before purchase
Customer concentration	One tenant is most of revenue	Mix powered shell, colocation and services; cap single-tenant share as you grow
Construction overrun	Long-lead items (transformers, switchgear) slip	Order long-lead kit early, contingency held separately, fixed milestones with the contractor

36-month timeline

Months	Milestone	Proof it is done
0-6	Site, power and anchor	Site option signed, grid offer in hand, anchor letter of intent
6-12	Design, permits, funding close	Permits issued, debt + equity closed, long-lead orders placed
12-24	Build shell, commission Phase 1	Commissioning passed, first hall live, anchor tenant moved in
24-36	Fill and expand	Phase 1 occupancy above target, Phase 2 funded from contracts

Measures of success - review quarterly

- Contracted MW vs. built MW (never let built run far ahead of contracted)
- PUE, tracked monthly, and power cost per MW sold
- Uptime against the service-level agreement (SLA), and mean time to repair
- Occupancy, revenue per MW, and cash runway in months
- Staff retention in critical roles, and open-role time-to-fill

Sources, links and your next steps

Sources for the figures in this plan

- IEA, *Energy and AI*, April 2025 - global use 415 TWh in 2024, 945 TWh base case by 2030, AI-optimised demand more than quadrupling, US accounting for almost half of demand growth to 2030: http://www.energyconnects.com/opinion/features/2025/april/iea-ai-to-accelerate-energy-innovation-and-drive-surging-electricity-demand/
- Construction cost benchmarks - shell $9-15M per MW ($900M-$1.5B per 100 MW, ex-IT), electrical ~50% of build, mechanical 15-20%, IT adding $2.5-4B per 100 MW, GPUs $25,000-$40,000 each: https://www.alpha-matica.com/post/deconstructing-the-data-center-a-look-at-the-cost-structure-1
- Employment roles and BLS May 2025 median pay benchmarks: https://www.apollotechnical.com/data-center-jobs/
- DOE / Lawrence Berkeley National Laboratory, *United States Data Center Energy Usage Report* (2024, with 2025 update coverage) - US context on pages 3-4.
- Uptime Institute, *Global Data Center Survey 2024* - industry average PUE of 1.56, broadly flat since about 2019.

Full links directory

Finance: SBA funding programs, DOE Loan Programs Office, Grants.gov, Treasury CDFI Fund, Visa small business tools - full URLs on page 7.
Employment: BLS Occupational Outlook, DOL employer resources, CareerOneStop Business Center, AWS data center careers, LinkedIn Talent Solutions, Indeed for Employers - full URLs on page 8.

Next steps - this month

[ ] Name the target region and score three candidate sites with the page 6 scorecard

[ ] Open the grid conversation with the utility - in writing, with a date

[ ] Talk to two potential anchor tenants before finalising hall design

[ ] Re-price page 7 for your site with a local estimator and an equipment quote

[ ] Check every finance and grant link on page 7 for current eligibility

[ ] Draft job descriptions for the facilities manager and lead electrical technician

[ ] Set the quarterly review: contracted MW, PUE, uptime, cash runway (page 9)

> **A note on live data:** This plan contains published, dated figures only - no simulated or live facility data. When a real facility exists and a real telemetry feed is connected, operating dashboards should show that feed, clearly labelled with its source and date.

Prepared October 2026 as a planning document. Figures are from the published sources above and must be verified for any specific investment, site or application. This document does not provide financial, legal or tax advice.